

Primary Source Reading 3: The Soul's Affinity, and Two Objections

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Plato's Phaedo, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 9c: The Affinity Argument

Before you read: The first two arguments showed that the soul exists before birth and knows the Forms. But Cebes's real worry — that a soul might simply wear out over time — remains. Socrates now argues from what kind of thing the soul actually is. As you read, watch for the sharp division between the visible and the invisible, and then for the two objections — Simmias's and Cebes's — that arrive as soon as Socrates finishes.

The Soul's Kinship with the Unseen

SOCRATES: And is the soul seen or not seen?

CEBES: Not seen.

SOCRATES: Unseen then?

CEBES: Yes.

SOCRATES: Then the soul is more like to the unseen, and the body to the seen?

CEBES: That follows necessarily.

SOCRATES: And were we not saying long ago that the soul, when using the sense of sight or hearing or some other sense, is then dragged by the body into the region of the changeable, and wanders and is confused; the world spins round her, and she is like a drunkard, when she touches change?

CEBES: Very true.

SOCRATES: But when returning into herself she reflects, then she passes into the other world, the region of purity, and eternity, and immortality, and unchangeableness, which are her kindred, and with them she ever lives, when she is by herself and is not let or hindered; then she ceases from her erring ways. (79a–d)

The Philosopher's Soul at Death

SOCRATES: That soul, I say, herself invisible, departs to the invisible world — to the divine and immortal and rational: thither arriving, she is secure of bliss and is released from the error and folly of men, their fears and wild passions and all other human ills, and for ever dwells, as they say of the initiated, in company with the gods. Is not this true, Cebes?

CEBES: Yes, beyond a doubt. (80d–81a)

[Socrates has just built the case for the soul's kinship with the eternal. Cebes and Simmias, who had listened in respectful silence, now visibly hesitate — and Socrates notices.]

Simmiias's Harmony Objection

SIMMIAS: Suppose a person to use the same argument about harmony and the lyre — might he not say that harmony is a thing invisible, incorporeal, perfect, divine, existing in the lyre which is harmonized, but that the lyre and the strings are matter and material, composite, earthy, and akin to mortality? And when some one breaks the lyre, or cuts and rends the strings, then he who takes this view would argue... that the harmony survives and has not perished — you cannot imagine, he would say, that the lyre without the strings, and the broken strings themselves which are mortal remain, and yet that the harmony, which is of heavenly and immortal nature and kindred, has perished — perished before the mortal...

The thought, Socrates, must have occurred to your own mind that such is our conception of the soul; and that when the body is in a manner strung and held together by the elements of hot and cold, wet and dry, then the soul is the harmony or due proportionate admixture of them. But if so, whenever the strings of the body are unduly loosened or overstrained through disease or other injury, then the soul, though most divine, like other harmonies of music or of works of art, of course perishes at once. (85e–86c)

Cebes's Cloak Objection

CEBES: The analogy which I will adduce is that of an old weaver, who dies, and after his death somebody says: — He is not dead, he must be alive; see, there is the coat which he himself wove and wore, and which remains whole and undecayed... For the truth is, that the weaver aforesaid, having woven and worn many such coats, outlived several of them, and was outlived by the last; but a man is not therefore proved to be slighter and weaker than a coat.

Now the relation of the body to the soul may be expressed in a similar figure... He may argue in like manner that every soul wears out many bodies, especially if a man live many years... But of course, whenever the soul perishes, she must have on her last garment, and this will survive her... nevertheless, we may be still inclined to think that she will weary in the labours of successive births, and may at last succumb in one of her deaths and utterly perish; and this death and dissolution of the body which brings destruction to the soul may be unknown to any of us, for no one of us can have had any experience of it. (87b–88a)

After you read: Both objections accept a great deal of what Socrates has argued and still resist the conclusion. Notice the difference between them: Simmiias worries that the soul might be *the wrong kind of thing* to survive the body — a dependent property rather than an independent substance. Cebes worries that even a long-lasting, independent soul might still, eventually, simply wear out. Socrates will need a different answer for each. The lesson calls this moment a turning point in the dialogue, and it is worth noticing why: for the first time, Plato has Socrates's argument genuinely falter in front of his friends.